

ON TECHNIQUE

Speech patterns

An interest in folklore was shared by many nationalist composers in central Europe during Janáček's lifetime, but his use of speech patterns was entirely new. He would notate the pitches and rhythms of the spoken Czech language and examine how "speech tunes" altered according to context and the speaker's state of mind. This enabled him to break free from the specter of Wagner and develop his music in a different way. The technique powers his operas such as *The Cunning Little Vixen*, but also his choral masterpiece, the *Glagolitic Mass*, and even his instrumental works, such as the *Sinfonietta*.

Much like his older compatriot and friend Antonín Dvořák, Leoš Janáček was an all-around musician. Born in Hukvaldy, Bohemia, in 1854, Leoš became a choirboy at the Abbey of St. Thomas in Brno; later, he studied at the organ school in Prague and then piano, organ, and composition in Leipzig. His teachers were impressed by his talent, although some regarded him as a problematic personality. At first, he eked out a living by giving piano lessons and conducting amateur choirs, while composing on the side.

In 1881, Janáček founded an organ school in Brno, and married one of his pupils, Zdenka Schulzová. During the next few years, his interest in folk music grew. He began collecting and studying traditional songs and dances of the region and in the early 1890s he became effectively the leader of folklorist activities in Moravia and Silesia, often translating elements of